Karabakh war, Moscow was anxious of the Taliban's emergence as a dominant force. With the Tajik civil war far from resolution and the 1991–93 Georgian Civil War fresh in memory, Moscow was clear in its anti-Taliban intent. Denouncing Pakistan's armed support to the militia, Nikolae Schevechenkova, head of Russia's diplomatic mission in Mazar-e-Sharif, said on 20 October 1996: 'If the Taliban comes to the North there will be terrible bloodshed. And if our borders are under threat we would take appropriate measures.'[113] Schevechenkova's tough message had political precedent. Moscow had already stationed a division worth of troops in Tajikistan near the Afghan border.

On 4 October 1996, Kazakhastan, the Kyrgyz Republic, Uzbekistan, Kazakhastan, and Russia had met in Almaty to discuss regional stability and security. Occurring just a week before the Tehran Conference, the Almaty meeting concluded that the Taliban was a direct threat to the domestic stability and national interests of the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS) member countries as well as the region. Though the various Central Asian nations were concerned about a heavier Russian military presence on their soil in the wake of the Taliban's rise, and were open to a negotiated settlement, they had limited say in the final outcome of the conference.[114] Turkmenistan, at the same time, was supplying energy to the Taliban and was firm on remaining on good terms with all Afghan protagonists (a classic conciliatory approach), in order to ensure safe passage of oil pipelines for which US and Argentinian firms such as Unocal and Bridas were actively lobbying the Taliban.[115] Issuing a joint statement at the end of the meeting, the CIS countries appealed to the Taliban to cease military activities and threatened that if this did not happen, the CIS would give an 'adequate response'.[116] Supporting the meeting, the MEA was keen on Russia's support on this issue. Having signed a defence agreement in 1997, Moscow and New Delhi were increasingly converging on various geopolitical issues.

For one, India paid heavy amounts to Russia for supplying weapons to the UF from Tajikistan. In the process, not only did the UF receive what it required to fight its battles, even the Russian defence industry received a boost.[117] Russia extended support to India on Kashmir, and India agreed to legitimise Russian military actions in international forums and strengthen bilateral relations throughout the 1990s. Critically, all Central Asian countries concurred with